

Focus Template

A plug-and-play daily system for building concentration, eliminating distraction, and maximizing deep work.

1. Core Focus System

What "Focus" Means in This System

Focus is not willpower. It is a **controlled environment + trained habit + clear target**.

In this system, focus = entering a defined state where:

- You know exactly what you're working on (one task)
- Your environment blocks distractions by default
- You work in structured time blocks with planned breaks
- You rate and track attention quality to improve over time

Deep Work vs. Shallow Work

	Deep Work	Shallow Work
Definition	Cognitively demanding, produces real output	Low-effort, logistical, reactive
Examples	Solving problems, writing essays, learning concepts	Replying to messages, organizing files, browsing
Brain state	Single-task, sustained attention	Multi-task, fragmented attention
In this system	Gets a formal Focus Session	Gets batched into a separate admin block

Rule: Deep work gets Focus Sessions. Shallow work gets batched into one 30-min admin block per day. Never mix them.

Minimum Setup Before Any Session

Before you start a single session, you need three things:

1. ONE clear goal → "What will I complete?"
2. ONE clean space → Desk cleared, materials ready
3. ONE blocked device → Phone silenced, face-down or in another room

If you can't do all three, don't start. Fix the setup first. A 25-minute session with proper setup beats 2 hours of distracted "work."

2. Focus Session Template

Copy and use this for every focus session.

FOCUS SESSION #__ Date: _____

 SESSION GOAL (one specific outcome):

 Subject / Topic:

 Time Block:

Start: _____ End: _____ Duration: ____ min

 PRE-SESSION SETUP (check all before starting)

Environment:

☐ Desk cleared — only study materials visible

☐ Water bottle filled and within reach

☐ Lighting adequate

☐ Noise controlled (quiet space / headphones on)

Digital:

☐ Phone on silent, face-down or in another room

☐ All non-study tabs/apps closed

☐ Notifications OFF on laptop/computer

☐ Study materials open and ready

 ENTRY RITUAL (3 minutes — do this every time)

1. Close eyes. 5 deep breaths (4 in, 4 out).
 2. Read your session goal out loud or in your head.
 3. Set timer for your focus block.
 4. Say or think: “One task. Nothing else.”
 5. Begin.
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 DURING SESSION — EXECUTION RULES

- Work ONLY on the stated goal. Nothing else.
 - If a thought or to-do pops up, write it on a “distraction pad” (paper next to you) and continue.
 - If you catch yourself drifting, say “refocus” and return to the task. No guilt. Just redirect.
 - Do NOT check your phone for any reason.
 - If stuck, sit with the discomfort for 2 minutes before switching approach.
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 BREAK (after session ends)

Duration: ____ min (5 min after short, 15 min after long)

☐ Stand up and move away from desk

☐ Stretch or walk (no screens)

☐ Drink water / snack if needed

[] Do NOT check social media during break

🚩 EXIT RITUAL (2 minutes — do this every time)

1. Write one sentence: What did I accomplish?

2. Note what to start with in the next session:

3. Rate this session below.

📊 SESSION RATING

Focus Quality: [1] [2] [3] [4] [5]

Distractions: [0] [1-2] [3-5] [5+]

Output Completed: [0%] [25%] [50%] [75%] [100%]

Phone Checked: [Yes] [No]

Notes:

Recommended Session Durations

Level	Duration	Break	Best For
Starter	25 min	5 min	Week 1, or when motivation is low
Standard	45 min	10 min	Week 2–3, most study sessions
Deep	60 min	15 min	Week 3–4, when focus is trained
Ultra	90 min	20 min	Week 4+, only for your best subject/flow state

Never go beyond 90 minutes without a break. Diminishing returns are real.

3. Daily Focus Plan

Daily Planning Template

Fill this in each morning (or the night before). Takes 5 minutes.

 **DAILY FOCUS PLAN** | Date: _____

 Energy Level Today: [Low] [Medium] [High]

 **TOP 3 PRIORITIES** (if I do nothing else, I must do these)

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

 SESSION PLAN

Session 1: _____ to _____

Task: _____

Subject: _____ Duration: ____ min Type: Hard / Medium / Easy

Session 2: _____ to _____

Task: _____

Subject: _____ Duration: ____ min Type: Hard / Medium / Easy

Session 3: _____ to _____

Task: _____

Subject: _____ Duration: ____ min Type: Hard / Medium / Easy

Session 4: _____ to _____ (optional)

Task: _____

Subject: _____ Duration: ____ min Type: Hard / Medium / Easy

Admin Block: _____ to _____ (30 min max)

Batch: emails, messages, logistics, organizing

 PHONE RULE TODAY:

☐ Off until lunch ☐ Airplane mode during sessions

☐ In another room ☐ Allowed only during breaks

 END-OF-DAY REVIEW (fill at night)

Sessions completed: ____ / ____

Top priority achieved? [Yes] [Partially] [No]

Biggest focus win: _____

Biggest distraction: _____

Tomorrow's #1 task: _____

Energy-Based Task Distribution

Always match task difficulty to energy level:

Time of Day	Typical Energy	Assign
Morning (7–11 AM)	   High	Hardest subject, new concepts, complex problems
Early afternoon (12–2 PM)	  Medium	Practice questions, review, medium-difficulty tasks
Late afternoon (3–5 PM)	 Low	Flashcards, light review, organizing notes
Evening (7–9 PM)	  Medium	Active recall, summary writing, next-day planning

How to Handle Low-Energy Days

When energy is low, don't skip — **scale down**:

Normal Plan	Low-Energy Alternative
4 sessions × 45 min	3 sessions × 25 min
Hard subject first	Medium subject first (build momentum)
Active problem-solving	Passive review → then light recall
5+ hours total	2–3 hours total (and that's okay)

The rule: A 25-minute session on a bad day > zero sessions. Protect the streak.

Burnout Prevention

Warning Sign	Action
Dreading every session	Cut session length by 50% for 2 days
Focus score averaging below 2/5	Take a half-day off, then restart
Physical symptoms (headaches, tension)	Stop. Move. Eat. Sleep. No negotiation.
Haven't had fun in 3+ days	Schedule 2 hours of pure leisure tonight

4. Distraction Control System

Phone Rules

Rule	Implementation
During focus sessions	Silent + face-down on desk OR in another room entirely
During breaks	Allowed for messages only (set a 3-min timer)
Nuclear option	Give your phone to someone else until your sessions are done
App control	Delete social media apps during exam period. Use browser-only if needed.

The Distraction Pad Method

Keep a blank piece of paper next to you during every focus session.

When a random thought, urge, or to-do pops into your head:

1. Write it on the pad (takes 3 seconds)
2. Return to your task immediately
3. Deal with everything on the pad AFTER the session ends

This works because it acknowledges the thought without acting on it. Your brain can let go of it once it's written down.

Mid-Session Distraction Recovery

When you catch yourself distracted (and you will):

Step 1: Notice it. No judgment. Say "distracted" in your head.

Step 2: Mark a tally on your distraction pad. ||||

Step 3: Re-read the last sentence you wrote / last problem you were on.

Step 4: Continue from there.

Total recovery time: ~10 seconds.

Do NOT restart the timer. Do NOT feel guilty. Redirect and continue.

Quick Focus Reset (When You're Completely Lost)

If you've been distracted for more than 5 minutes:

1. Stand up. (physically move)
2. 5 deep breaths. (reset nervous system)
3. Splash cold water on your face. (physiological alert)
4. Sit back down.
5. Re-read your session goal out loud.
6. Set a fresh 15-minute mini-timer.
7. Work for just those 15 minutes. Then decide if you continue.

Environmental Control

Factor	Ideal Setup	Quick Fix
Noise	Quiet room with door closed	Noise-cancelling headphones + white noise or brown noise
Visual clutter	Clean desk, only current materials	Throw everything into a box or bag, out of sight
People	Study alone or with silent studiers	Tell others: "I'm in a focus block until [time]"
Temperature	Slightly cool (helps alertness)	Open a window or adjust fan
Lighting	Bright, natural light preferred	Desk lamp on, overhead light on, no dim/cozy lighting

5. Attention Training Progression (30 Days)

Your ability to focus is a skill. It improves with training. Here's how it progresses:

Week 1: Adaptation (Days 1–7)

Goal: Build the habit of structured sessions. Don't worry about duration.

Parameter	Setting
Session length	25 minutes
Sessions per day	2–3
Break length	5 minutes
Phone rule	Silent, face-down
Expected focus score	2–3/5 (this is normal)

What to expect:

- Constant urge to check your phone
- Mind wandering every 5–10 minutes
- Sessions feel long and uncomfortable

- Breaks feel too short

What to do: Follow the template mechanically. Don't judge your performance. Just complete the sessions.

Week 2: Building Consistency (Days 8–14)

Goal: Increase duration and reduce distraction frequency.

Parameter	Setting
Session length	35–45 minutes
Sessions per day	3–4
Break length	10 minutes
Phone rule	In another room
Expected focus score	3–3.5/5

What to expect:

- Phone urges start to decrease
- You can sustain 20+ minutes before first distraction
- Entry ritual starts feeling automatic
- You begin noticing when you're drifting (awareness improves)

What to do: Start tracking distraction tallies. Try to reduce by 1 per session each day.

Week 3: Deep Focus Strengthening (Days 15–21)

Goal: Sustain deep focus and increase output quality.

Parameter	Setting
Session length	45–60 minutes
Sessions per day	3–4
Break length	10–15 minutes
Phone rule	In another room, notifications off
Expected focus score	3.5–4/5

What to expect:

- You can work 30–40 minutes before your first distraction
- Output per session noticeably increases
- You start craving the structure (habit formed)
- Entry ritual takes under 2 minutes

What to do: Introduce one 60-minute session per day. Attempt interleaving (switching subjects between sessions).

Week 4: Mastery & Stability (Days 22–30)

Goal: Lock in the system as automatic behavior.

Parameter	Setting
Session length	45–90 minutes (flexible)
Sessions per day	3–5
Break length	10–20 minutes
Phone rule	Automatic — you don't even think about it
Expected focus score	4–5/5

What to expect:

- Focus feels natural, not forced
- You can enter deep work within 2–3 minutes
- Distractions per session drop to 0–2
- You can choose session length based on the task
- The system is now your default mode

30-Day Focus Progression Tracker

Week	Avg Session (min)	Avg Focus Score	Avg Distractions/Session	Phone Checks/Day
Week 1	___	___/5	___	___
Week 2	___	___/5	___	___

Week	Avg Session (min)	Avg Focus Score	Avg Distractions/Session	Phone Checks/Day
Week 3	___	___/5	___	___
Week 4	___	___/5	___	___

6. Personalization Guide

Adjust for Your Attention Span

Your Span	Session Length	Sessions/Day	Strategy
Very short (can't focus 10 min)	15 min	5–6 short	Many micro-sessions. Increase by 5 min each week.
Short (10–20 min)	25 min	3–4	Standard pomodoro. Focus on completing, not extending.
Average (20–40 min)	45 min	3	Standard system. Extend to 60 min in Week 3.
Long (40+ min naturally)	60–90 min	2–3	Fewer, longer blocks. Use breaks strictly — don't skip them.

Adjust for Your Workload

Workload	Daily Focus Hours	Session Count	Notes
Light (1–2 subjects, low pressure)	2–3 hrs	2–3	Focus on quality. One deep session per subject.
Medium (3–4 subjects, exams coming)	4–5 hrs	3–4	Standard plan. Rotate subjects across sessions.

Workload	Daily Focus Hours	Session Count	Notes
Heavy (5+ subjects, exams imminent)	5–6.5 hrs	4–5	Max capacity. Strict breaks. No evening study.

Adjust for Your Environment

Environment	Modifications
Quiet home/library	Use the system as designed. No modifications needed.
Noisy home	Headphones mandatory. Brown noise or lo-fi study music (no lyrics). Close the door. Set "do not disturb" rules with family.
Shared room	Study in a library or café. If stuck at home, use headphones + face a wall.
No private space	Find your "study spot" outside home (library, café, empty classroom). Go there every day — same place builds routine.

Adjust for Your Motivation Level

Motivation	What To Do
High	Follow the plan as written. Push for longer sessions.
Medium	Start with the easiest version of the hardest task to build momentum.
Low	Commit to just ONE 15-minute session. That's it. After 15 minutes, decide if you continue. (You usually will.)
Zero	Do the entry ritual only (5 deep breaths + read your goal). Then set a timer for 10 minutes. If you truly can't start, take the day off and restart tomorrow.

The "just 10 minutes" rule: On your worst days, commit to 10 minutes only. Start the timer. Begin working. In most cases, inertia carries you past the 10-minute mark. If not, you still did 10 minutes — that's not zero.

Adjust for Distraction Addiction

Level	Signs	Protocol
Mild	Check phone 1–2x per session	Phone face-down on desk. Track checks.
Moderate	Can't go 15 min without phone	Phone in another room. Physical distance is the only cure.
Severe	Unlock phone unconsciously during sessions	Give phone to someone else. Or lock it in a drawer and put the key elsewhere. Delete social media apps for the exam period.
Extreme	Phone is the first and last thing you touch daily	Set a "phone curfew": no phone before 9 AM and after 9 PM. Use an alarm clock instead of phone alarm. Charge phone outside bedroom.

7. Daily Focus Checklist

Before Starting (Morning)

- ☐ Decide today's top 3 priorities
- ☐ Plan session times and tasks
- ☐ Set phone to silent / put in another room
- ☐ Clear desk — only today's materials
- ☐ Fill water bottle
- ☐ Write down session goals

During Each Focus Session

- ☐ Entry ritual done (breaths + goal + timer)

- ☐ Working on ONE task only
- ☐ Distraction pad ready
- ☐ Phone untouched
- ☐ Redirecting drift without guilt

After Each Session

- ☐ Exit ritual done (what I accomplished + next session note)
- ☐ Focus quality rated (1–5)
- ☐ Distractions counted
- ☐ Break taken (no screens)

End of Day

- ☐ All sessions rated
- ☐ Biggest win identified
- ☐ Biggest distraction identified
- ☐ Tomorrow's #1 priority written down
- ☐ Phone plugged in away from bed
- ☐ In bed by target time

8. Example Full-Day Focus Plan

Student: Exam prep, 3 subjects, medium energy day

 **FULL DAY FOCUS PLAN** | Date: Tuesday

 Energy: Medium

 Phone Rule: In kitchen drawer until 1 PM

TOP 3 PRIORITIES

1. Complete 15 practice questions in Math (algebra + calculus)
2. Write Biology summary sheet for genetics chapter

3. Review History essay structure for 1848 question

SESSION 1 — 07:30 to 08:15 (45 min)

Subject: Math (🔴 hardest — gets morning energy)

Goal: Solve 8 algebra problems without looking at solutions

Method: Practice problems → check answers → re-do wrong ones

☕ BREAK 08:15–08:25 (10 min) — walk to kitchen, refill water

SESSION 2 — 08:30 to 09:15 (45 min)

Subject: Math continued

Goal: Solve 7 calculus problems

Method: Timed practice → mark → note errors for tomorrow

☕ BREAK 09:15–09:30 (15 min) — stretch, snack, bathroom

SESSION 3 — 09:45 to 10:30 (45 min)

Subject: Biology

Goal: Write one-page genetics summary sheet from memory

Method: Close textbook → write everything I know → check → fill gaps

☕ BREAK 10:30–10:45 (15 min) — short walk outside

SESSION 4 — 11:00 to 11:40 (40 min)

Subject: History

Goal: Outline a full essay answer for the 1848 revolutions question

Method: Write intro + 3 body paragraphs + conclusion structure

🍴 LUNCH 11:45–13:00 — full break, eat properly, check phone (15 min max)

ADMIN BLOCK — 13:00 to 13:30 (30 min)

- Reply to messages
- Organize tomorrow's materials
- Check exam timetable

 Phone goes back in drawer at 13:30

SESSION 5 (Optional) — 14:00 to 14:30 (30 min)

Subject: Biology review

Goal: Self-test on yesterday's ecology chapter

Method: Write 10 recall questions → answer without notes → grade

 EXERCISE — 15:00 to 15:45 — walk / run / gym

 FREE TIME — 16:00 to 19:00

EVENING REVIEW — 19:00 to 19:30 (30 min)

- Flip through today's summary sheet
- Write 5 things I remember from each session (no notes)
- Write tomorrow's top 3 priorities
- Pack tomorrow's materials

 Wind down from 20:00. No study. In bed by 22:00.

DAY RESULTS

Sessions completed: ____/5

Total focus time: ~3.5 hrs (realistic, sustainable)

Distractions total: ____

Phone checks: ____

Focus score average: ____/5

Session I'm proudest of: _____

What I'll do differently tomorrow: _____

What This Day Achieves

Metric	Value
Focused study hours	3.5 hrs (high quality)
Subjects covered	3
Practice questions done	15+
Summary sheets created	1
Active recall sessions	2
Phone exposure	<30 minutes total
Free time	4+ hours
Sleep target	8 hours

This is sustainable for 30 days. That's the point.

Quick Reference Card

FOCUS SESSION IN 60 SECONDS

1. Clear desk
2. Phone away
3. Write ONE goal
4. 5 breaths
5. Set timer
6. Work (one task only)
7. Distractions → pad (don't act on them)

8. Timer ends → write what you did → rate it
9. Break (no screens)
10. Repeat

That's the entire system.

"You do not rise to the level of your goals. You fall to the level of your systems."

Start with one session. Then do it again tomorrow. 🔥

Before You Leave

If you have read this far, then you are already different from most students.

Most people want better results, but very few are willing to study deeply enough to change the way they think, learn, and work. My hope is that this book becomes more than something you read. I hope it becomes something you practice.

I will continue creating resources for students who want to:

- move from average grades to academic excellence
- build stronger study systems
- learn faster and more effectively
- develop discipline and deep focus
- and compete at a higher academic level

This book is only the starting point.

You can find more materials, future releases, and additional resources from me through the links and platforms below.

<https://selar.com/m/david-itoya1>

Keep doing the hard things.

They change you.

— David Itoya

One More Thing Before You Go

If you enjoyed this book, there is a good chance you are the kind of person who cares deeply about growth — not just academically, but personally and professionally as well.

And while this book focused on helping you improve your academic performance, many of the same principles apply far beyond school:

- disciplined thinking
- systems over motivation
- deep work
- consistency
- learning valuable skills
- and building a life intentionally instead of randomly

That is part of why I created Scale Group.

Scale Group is a community and educational platform originally built for Nigerian entrepreneurs, creators, freelancers, and ambitious young people who want to grow financially and think at a higher level.

Now, you do **not** need to own a business to join.

In fact, many people inside are students — people trying to:

- build useful skills
- understand how money and business actually work
- become more disciplined
- meet growth-minded people
- and position themselves better for life after university

Inside the community, we share:

- practical frameworks
- business and growth lessons
- mindset shifts
- real-world case studies
- opportunities
- and conversations designed to help people think bigger and execute better

Most importantly, it is free to join.

So if you want to continue learning, growing, and surrounding yourself with people who are serious about becoming better, you are welcome to join us.

→ Join the Community here:

<https://chat.whatsapp.com/HLtfMHU31JXGCvVZUbLSoT>

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